

The Baron of Ardaithe Session Zero

Dungeons & Dragons is a structured yet open-ended role-playing Table-top game. There is technically no winning or losing rather the goal is to tell fun and interesting stories together.

Your character sheet is one of the things you'll refer to most while playing, it contains ALL of your character information such as: equipment, spells, skills, XP, etc. Below is an example character sheet with explanations of each section.

Character Information: Stihsele Helvi (DM), 18th level, 180 ft. height, 180 lb. weight, 180 ft. reach. Campaign: The Baron of Ardaithe.

Key Buttons: SHORT REST, LONG REST, CAMPAIGN: The Baron of Ardaithe.

Hit Points (HP): 182 / 182. Current: 182, Max: 182, Temp: --.

Proficiency Bonus: +6. Walking Speed: 30 ft.

Initiative: +8. Armour Class: 18.

Skills: DEX Acrobatics +8, WIS Animal Handling +8, INT Arcana +15, STR Athletics +8, CHA Deception +5, INT History +15, WIS Insight +8, CHA Intimidation +5, INT Investigation +9, WIS Medicine +8, INT Nature +15, WIS Perception +14, CHA Performance +5, INT Religion +9, DEX Sleight of Hand +8, DEX Stealth +14, WIS Survival +8.

Passive Traits: STR +8, DEX +8, INT +15, WIS +8, CHA +5, CON +5. SAVING THROWS: STR +8, DEX +8, INT +15, WIS +8, CHA +5, CON +5. SENSES: Darkvision 60 ft.

Armor: None. Weapons: Crossbow, Light, Dagger, Dart, Longbow, Longsword, Quarterstaff, Shortbow, Shortsword, Sling. Tools: None. Languages: Common, Draconic, Elvish, Sylvan.

Actions: ATTACK: Quarterstaff (Simple, Versatile), Chill Touch (D, 180d, V/S), Fire Bolt (W/S), Unarmed Strike (S, 180d, V/S). ACTIONS IN COMBAT: Attack, Cast a Spell, Dash, Disengage, Dodge, Grapple, Help, Hide, Improvise, Ready, Search, Show, Use an Object.

Callouts:

- Your Character's icon, Name, gender, race, class, level, and XP is presented here. Clicking on your name will bring up the options to customise the theme of your character sheet. As well as options to share and export your sheet. You can also manage your character settings here (when agreed upon with your DM).
- Here the key buttons are the "short rest" and "long rest". A short rest is a period of downtime, at least 1 hour long, during which a character does nothing more strenuous than eating, drinking, reading, and tending to wounds. A long rest is a period of extended downtime, at least 8 hours long, during which a character sleeps for at least 6 hours and performs no more than 2 hours of light activity, such as reading, talking, eating, or standing watch. If the long rest is interrupted then it must start again.
- In this section you can find your hit points (HP): current and max + temp, and on the left of the section is a function to add or subtract HP typically during combat when taking damage or when healing using a spell or potion.
- Inspiration is a rule the game master can use to reward you for playing your character in a way that's true to his or her personality traits, ideal, bond, and flaw. If you have inspiration, you can expend it when you make an attack roll, saving throw, or ability check. Spending your inspiration gives you advantage on that roll. You can also give up your inspiration to other players if you feel they do good roleplaying, clever thinking, or simply doing something exciting in the game.
- A saving throw — also called a save — represents an attempt to resist a spell, a trap, a poison, a disease, or a similar threat. You don't normally decide to make a saving throw; you are forced to make one because your character or monster is at risk of harm. Below are potential advantages your character may have for example advantages against being charmed.
- Here in this section your passive traits including things like darkvision (which allows you to see in dim areas) are located. A passive check is a special kind of ability check that doesn't involve any die rolls. Such a check can represent the average result for a task done repeatedly, such as searching for secret doors over and over again, or can be used when the DM wants to secretly determine whether the characters succeed at something without rolling dice, such as noticing a hidden monster.
- This section is good for quick reference especially the languages section. Often in the world of D&D you may overhear things in various languages and your character won't always understand. Similarly if your proficient in using certain tools or weapons can get various bonuses.
- There are 4 key pieces of information in this section: Proficiency bonus, Walking speed, Initiative, and Armour class. Walking speed refers to which is the distance in feet that the character can walk in 1 round. This number assumes short bursts of energetic movement in the midst of a life-threatening situation. Your proficiency bonus is determined by level and is used in the rules on ability checks, saving throws, and attack rolls. Your character's Initiative is rolled usually at the start of combat and determines the order of turns during combat. Finally, Armour Class refers to how well your character avoids being wounded in battle. Things that contribute to your AC include the armor you wear, the shield you carry, and your Dexterity modifier.
- In this section you can keep track of any immunities and conditions that have befallen your character. In the conditions section (usually via combat) status effects such as "blinded", "restrained", or "grappled" will result in various disadvantages affecting your player actions. A key condition when you decide to push past your character's limits is the exhaustion state. Exhaustion has various levels (usually 1 to 6) and each level effects your character from giving a disadvantage on ability checks to death.
- This section of the character sheet is the most dense part. The key parts are at the top of the section: Actions, Spells, Inventory, Features & Traits, Description, Notes, and Extras. These are more or less self-explanatory and contain all of your items, weapons, spells, equipment, character alignments, faith, physical description, etc. During a session you will flick back and forth through this section regularly. Key points to remember about this section are the inventory section is particular the equipment you have equipped, the secondary storage (backpack), and the attainment section for using magical items. Similarly the spells section is important for any spellcasting classes. It's important to refer to the class tables for the number of cantrips, and levelled spells your character knows and can use per short / long rest. A key section in actions includes other actions such as "Arcana Recovery" which once per long rest your character can choose up to 10 spell slots to recover after a short rest. There are many similar actions such as this and the section helps keep track of them. When expending a spell slot fill in the square checkbox. When all your spell slots have been expended your character will no longer have enough energy to cast any more spells (except cantrips which can be cast at will).

(This Image is available at a high resolution attached alongside the session zero .pdf file in the discord server)

To make D&D as enjoyable as possible while also being a safe space for players express your expectations not just with the DM but also with other players. Decide what kind of content does and does not have a place at your collective table. Similarly, table etiquette and house rules are important to make sure everyone is safe and enjoying the game. Below you can find the expected table etiquette:

Table Etiquette:

1. PAY ATTENTION

- This rule is neither surprising nor difficult, When the DM is talking, when players are taking actions, when combat is raging, don't interrupt or talk over the person and put you phone away (unless using it to lookup certain game related queries). Players and DMs alike put time and effort into telling the story together. An inattentive group member can make others feel like their contributions don't matter as much

2. BE PREPARED

- As a player, your preparation before the game includes getting to know your character sheet, preparing a backstory, and getting as familiar as possible with the rules and dice of Dungeons & Dragons. That doesn't mean you have to memorize every rule and character ability

3. SHARE THE SPOTLIGHT

- Some people love roleplaying their characters and doing so comes naturally to them. Others, not so much. If players or DMs who love roleplaying don't make a conscious effort to share the spotlight with other, quieter members of the group, then the game can feel unbalanced. Allow every player to express what they want their character to do, their opinion when forming plans, and look to set up moments for success for others

4. RESPECT TIME AND SCHEDULES

- Scheduling sessions is famously difficult for many D&D and other tabletop game groups. Most of us have lives outside of game night, including work, school, partners, kids, pets, vacations, and more. That's why respecting others' time is vital when it comes to D&D etiquette, both for the players and the DM. For all group members, this means showing up on time for scheduled sessions—or notifying everyone in your group in advance if you have to cancel

5. PLAY NICE

- If you want to know how to be a good D&D player, follow this rule: Play nice! Both in and out of character. It can be fun to play a character who pushes the envelope at times—the dodgy rogue with sticky fingers, the daring bard with a devil-may-care attitude, the loose-cannon barbarian with a temper. But when your character's decisions disrupt the game for everyone else, or if you find yourself justifying poor behaviour with "It's what my character would do," then it might be time to reign it in. Remember D&D is a team game, and it requires a collaborative effort

6. AVOID METAGAMING

- Speaking of being a good D&D player, you should avoid metagaming as much as possible. Metagaming is when you use the knowledge that you have as a player (that your character doesn't) to make choices that your character would not otherwise make.* For example, if Jasmine, as a player sitting at the table, knows that red dragons are immune to fire damage, but her character, a young halfling who knows nothing about dragons, doesn't know that, then she should make choices based only on what her character knows—that might mean her character shoots a firebolt at the dragon only to discover that it's immune` *For some players, it's tempting to metagame because that seems like the best way to win. It's important to remember that the primary goal of D&D and other tabletop RPGs is not "to win the game." Mistakes, failures, accidents, and even character deaths can enrich the game and often make for the best stories. Don't be afraid to make the less optimal choice if it makes sense for your character

7. GET NARRATIVE CONSENT

- Getting narrative consent means making sure everyone is on board with what's happening in the story and with their characters. This doesn't mean the characters will never fail or die (the dice giveth, and the dice taketh away). It means players and DMs shouldn't mess with another person's character unless that player is okay with it

8. RESOLVE CONFLICT OFF THE TABLE

- I hope all of your D&D groups are wonderful and perfect, but there's a chance you may run into a problem player at some point (or a problem DM for that matter). And you'll have to learn how to handle that person's behaviour. There's no silver bullet that will work for every kind of toxic behaviour, but here's one principle that applies across the board: Handle it outside of the game. The only conflicts you should be solving in-game are the fictional ones. All others require real talk with real human beings

Table Expectations:

These expectations are specific to each campaign, for the specific campaign we'll be journeying through, the number one expectation is that we all uphold the table etiquette out of respect for each other. Food, alcohol, and other soft drinks / snacks, etc are welcome at the table however be aware of the sound your making across the microphone. Not everyone wants to roleplay or is not confident in roleplaying and so we're not going to force anyone to do anything they're not comfortable with. This is a safe space however so if you want to try putting on a voice or attempt at roleplaying then the table will not judge and support the effort of ALL players.

As players you have narrative freedom when describing how your character feels, looks, acts, as well as the describing things you see, how spells and attacks look, how actions feel or look, etc. This can also include describing how wagons look like, the interior of buildings not described by the DM, how player related characters look like, etc. There is great freedom for narrative control for the players. The only limits to this narrative freedom are the NPCs, key story characters, and any storyline features already predetermined by the DM.

Something to be aware of is retconning. Retconning in D&D is when players and DMs revise (an aspect of a fictional work) retrospectively, typically by introducing a piece of new information that imposes a different interpretation on previously described events. Occasionally this is necessary to make sense of the story and or actions of characters. However, this is something to be avoided at all costs as it breaks the game of D&D for everyone involved and will ruin the authority of the die and the collaborative storytelling if for instance you fail an action you cannot retcon the action to prevent the failure.

Finally, player vs player action will not be allowed in this campaign as the majority of our group are new players. pvp is extremely sketchy and difficult to implement in a fair and fulfilling way that benefits the goal of collective storytelling.

House Rules:

Generating Character Statistics:

We've already created characters but the important discussion we had was after the first 2 sessions if you're not having a good time with your character, you may change your race / class and stats to something else. Typically, I'll allow 2 sessions of play for character changing before setting things in concrete

Levelling up:

In our campaign we'll use the XP levelling system, I'll award the XP as the DM accordingly for things like combat, travelling, doing things in character, etc

alignment:

For alignments there will be restrictions on evil alignments. As the table is populated by new players and evil alignment characters are hard to play with for all players

Character Backgrounds:

For the character backgrounds the most important thing is to check the lore of the source material for the campaign, so our characters make sense within the context of the campaign and world. The campaign is using source material from "*Dragonlance*" and "*Basic Rules*"

Character Death & Resurrection:

Characters in D&D can and will die permanently. Rarely they can be resurrected using spells such as *revivify* or via divine blessings. However, these are incredibly rare